

The Overcall

How to enter the opponents' auction: three ways, each with its own requirements.

1 Three ways to compete

An overcall is the first call other than Pass by the side opposite the opener. It is a **free choice**: you come in only when it pays.

Double

Short in the opponent's suit, the other three suits playable. 12–16 points.

1NT

Like a 1NT opening: 15–17 balanced, with a **stopper** in opener's suit.

Suit overcall

A very good suit, or plenty of points that fit neither the double nor 1NT. 16/17 at most.

2 The takeout double

The double asks partner to choose a suit and bid it at the level partner thinks you can play.

over 1♣ or 1♦

both majors: 4-4 or 4-3, never 4-2

over 1♥

promises 4 spades

over 1♠

promises 4 hearts

South opens 1♦, West to bid

♠ KJ98 ♥ AQ74 ♦ 5 ♣ K983

Double: both four-card majors, a singleton diamond and the right strength.

South opens 1♣, your call

♠ 9854 ♥ K4 ♦ A765 ♣ AJ3

Pass: the points are there, but hearts are missing. Partner would feel betrayed.

3 The doubler's partner

Advancer must pick a suit: the minimum for bidding at the cheapest level is zero points.

1♦ – Double – Pass – ?

♠ 54 ♥ J986 ♦ 952 ♣ Q532

1♥: never pass. 1♦ doubled would be a disaster.

1♦ – Double – Pass – ?

♠ KJ954 ♥ A76 ♦ 95 ♣ K64

4♠: bid as if you could see partner's cards, at least 4-3 in the majors.

1♦ – Double – Pass – ?

♠ K42 ♥ Q86 ♦ AJ10 ♣ K954

3NT: enough points, no major fit, a diamond stopper.

4 The 1NT overcall

Same strength and shape as a 1NT opening. The opponents already have a suit to lead, so you **need a stopper** in opener's suit.

South opens 1♥, West to bid

♠ AJ5 ♥ KJ7 ♦ AJ1053 ♣ K8

1NT: 17 points, balanced, a heart stopper.

5 The suit overcall

At the one level: 8–16 points, 5 cards with at least one honor (rarely 4 with two honors), or any 6 cards.

South opens 1♦

♠ 82 ♥ AKJ1042 ♦ 86 ♣ 983

1♥: 8 points, all of them in the suit.

6 Suit overcall, two level

10–16 points, usually **6 cards** with at least one honor. Exception: over 1♠, five hearts are enough, with an honor and 13+ points.

South opens 1♠

♠ 54 ♥ 98 ♦ KQJ862 ♣ A76

2♦: six cards with honors, 10 points.

Above 16/17 points don't overcall: double first, then bid your suit.

7 The overcaller's partner

Advancer starts from the **guaranteed minimum**. With **9+ points** never pass: $16 + 9 = 25$, game is possible. You may raise with only three cards.

Before you bid a suit, remember partner will lead it. If that makes your hair stand on end, the overcall is wrong.

In competitive auctions, 70% of the time opener's side buys the contract: every overcall guides the defense.